

Decade of Democracy (1988-1999) in Pakistan



The **Decade of Democracy** in Pakistan (1988–1999) saw the return of civilian governments after over a decade of military rule under General Zia-ul-Haq. However, despite the return to democracy, the period was marred by political instability, economic challenges, and growing tension between civilian administrations and the military, ultimately ending with a military coup in 1999.

- **Benazir Bhutto's First Term (1988-1990)**
- **Nawaz Sharif's First Term (1990-1993)**
- **Benazir Bhutto's Second Term (1993-1996)**
- **Nawaz Sharif's Second Term (1997-1999)**

Benazir Bhutto's First Term (1988-1990)

Election Date: 1988 – The first general elections held after General Zia-ul-Haq's death in a plane crash on August 17, 1988.

Benazir Bhutto's Election: The **Pakistan People's Party (PPP)**, led by **Benazir Bhutto**, won the elections. Bhutto became **Pakistan's first female Prime Minister** and the first woman to head a Muslim-majority nation.

Economic Challenges: Pakistan was in a severe economic crisis following Zia's rule, with high inflation (over **10%**), widespread unemployment (more than **15%**), and stagnant industrial growth.

Military-Civil Relations: Bhutto initially had **strained relations** with the military. She had to contend with military influence, especially from then-**Chief of Army Staff, General Waheed Kakar**, who played a pivotal role in the **1988 civil-military power struggle**.

Dismissal: Bhutto's government was dismissed by **President Ghulam Ishaq Khan** in **1990**, citing mismanagement and corruption under Article **58(2)(b)** of the Constitution, which allowed the president to dismiss the Prime Minister.

Nawaz Sharif's First Term (1990-1993)

1990 General Elections: Nawaz Sharif's Pakistan Muslim League-Nawaz (PML-N) won the **1990 elections**, securing **73 out of 217 seats** in the National Assembly.

Economic Reforms: Sharif's government aimed to implement economic reforms, including the introduction of a **new taxation system**, and privatization of state enterprises. However, his administration faced an **economic downturn** with continued inflation (hovering around **12-13%**) and low foreign exchange reserves.

Civil-Military Tensions: Despite early cooperation, tensions arose between Sharif and the military, particularly over civilian control and budgetary allocations. The military was growing more assertive, especially over foreign policy and national security issues.

Dismissal: Ghulam Ishaq Khan dismissed Nawaz Sharif's government in **April 1993** under charges of misgovernance, corruption, and political mismanagement. This was the **second dismissal** of a democratically elected government in Pakistan within five years.

Resignations: Following intervention from the **Supreme Court**, both Ishaq Khan and Nawaz Sharif resigned, leading to an interim government and the restoration of a more **balanced power-sharing agreement** between the President and Prime Minister.

Benazir Bhutto's Second Term (1993-1996)

1993 General Elections: Benazir Bhutto returned to power after the **1993 elections**, securing **87 seats** in the National Assembly.

Power-Sharing Agreement: A **power-sharing agreement** was made between Benazir Bhutto and **President Farooq Leghari**, in which Bhutto agreed to share powers with the office of the President. This period marked relative **stability** for the government compared to earlier terms.

Economic Issues: Despite an initial period of optimism, economic issues persisted. Pakistan continued to face **high unemployment** (around **10-12%**), and the GDP growth rate remained low, averaging **3-4%** per year.

Corruption Allegations: Bhutto's government was marred by **allegations of corruption**, including accusations that members of her family were involved in financial wrongdoing, particularly in **overseas assets**.

Dismissal: In **1996**, President **Farooq Leghari** dismissed Benazir Bhutto's government for the second time, citing corruption and inefficiency. The **Supreme Court** upheld the dismissal, which deepened the **political instability**.

Nawaz Sharif's Second Term (1997-1999)

1997 General Elections: Nawaz Sharif won the **1997 elections**, securing a **landslide** with **137 seats** out of **217** in the National Assembly, a clear majority.

Islamization of Laws: Sharif's government took a more **Islamic direction**, introducing the **Shariah Ordinance** and aiming to implement **Islamic laws** in several areas. This move was controversial but received support from conservative religious groups.

Kargil Conflict (1999): One of the defining moments of Sharif's second term was the **Kargil War** (May to July 1999), in which Pakistani troops, along with militants, infiltrated Indian territory in the **Kargil region** of Jammu and Kashmir. The military, led by **General Pervez Musharraf**, initiated the conflict, but Nawaz Sharif sought to de-escalate the situation and negotiated a withdrawal under international pressure, especially from the **United States**.

Conflict with the Military: Sharif's decision to withdraw Pakistani forces from Kargil without consulting the military leadership led to a **deep rift** between the civilian government and the military, specifically General **Pervez Musharraf**.

Coup d'état (1999): On **October 12, 1999**, after Nawaz Sharif attempted to dismiss **General Pervez Musharraf** as Chief of Army Staff, a military coup unfolded. **Musharraf** seized power and declared himself Chief Executive, ending the democratic experiment in Pakistan.

Key Issues During the Decade of Democracy (1988–1999)

The **Decade of Democracy** in Pakistan, spanning from **1988 to 1999**, was characterized by significant political turmoil, instability, and a continued struggle for control between civilian governments and the military. Despite the return to democracy after **Zia-ul-Haq's military rule**, civil-military relations, corruption, economic struggles, and political instability dominated the decade. These issues severely impacted the functioning of democratic institutions and contributed to the eventual military coup of **1999**.

- **Civil-Military Relations**
- **Corruption**
- **Economic Struggles**
- **Judiciary and Political Instability**

Civil-Military Relations

Throughout the 1990s, **civil-military relations** in Pakistan were a persistent source of tension. Even though Pakistan had elected civilian governments, the military retained significant influence over key areas, such as **foreign policy**, **national security**, and even economic decisions. For example, in **1993**, **Nawaz Sharif's** government was forced to step down after a standoff with **President Ghulam Ishaq Khan**, who was supported by the military. The intervention of **General Waheed Kakar**, the Chief of Army Staff at the time, helped broker a **political agreement**, which ultimately resulted in both Sharif and Ishaq Khan stepping down. This event highlighted how the military and the judiciary often played a dominant role in political decisions, sidelining civilian governance. The most dramatic example occurred in **1999**, when **General Pervez Musharraf** led a military coup against **Nawaz Sharif**, ousting him from power. Musharraf declared himself **Chief Executive** of Pakistan, marking the end of civilian rule.

Corruption

Corruption was widespread during the decade, involving leaders from both the **Pakistan People's Party (PPP)** and the **Pakistan Muslim League-Nawaz (PML-N)**. For instance, **Benazir Bhutto's** government faced major allegations of corruption, most notably regarding **Swiss bank accounts**. In **1993**, Swiss authorities froze accounts linked to **Benazir Bhutto's family**, following allegations that they had stashed ill-gotten wealth there through kickbacks and money laundering. This case became widely known as the **Swiss bank scandal**. Similarly, **Nawaz Sharif's government** was accused of corruption during the privatization of state-owned enterprises. The **National Bank of Pakistan**, for example, was alleged to have given out loans to favored businesses and individuals without following proper procedures. The public perception of widespread corruption weakened both governments, and critics, including the military, used these scandals as a justification for their intervention in politics.

Economic Struggles

Pakistan's economy during the decade faced **persistent struggles**. For example, the GDP growth rate was low, averaging between **3% and 4%**, which was insufficient to create jobs for the growing population. This led to high unemployment rates, fluctuating between **10% and 15%**, and increased social unrest. Inflation was another major issue, with average rates ranging between **10% and 15%**. This high inflation caused prices to skyrocket, making daily life difficult for ordinary citizens. A specific example of Pakistan's economic challenges was the rising **foreign debt**, which climbed to over **\$20 billion** by the end of the decade. The country had to borrow heavily from international lenders like the **World Bank** and the **International Monetary Fund (IMF)** to meet its financial obligations. These loans often came with tough conditions that further strained Pakistan's economy and limited the government's ability to invest in public welfare and development projects.

Judiciary and Political Instability

Political instability was a hallmark of the 1990s in Pakistan, with frequent changes in government, the dismissal of prime ministers, and the intervention of the **judiciary**. For example, in **1990**, the **Supreme Court** played a pivotal role in the dismissal of **Benazir Bhutto** by upholding the decision of **President Ghulam Ishaq Khan** under **Article 58(2)(b)**, which allowed the president to dismiss the prime minister. The court ruled that Bhutto's government was guilty of corruption and mismanagement, though critics argued that the dismissal was politically motivated. Similarly, in **1993**, the **Supreme Court** again intervened when **Nawaz Sharif** and **President Ishaq Khan** faced a constitutional crisis. The military and judiciary stepped in to mediate, forcing both leaders to step down in what became known as the **Kakar Plan**. This constant judicial intervention and political turnover weakened Pakistan's political institutions, leading to a **military coup** in **1999**. After the coup, **General Musharraf** took control of the government, further deepening the cycle of instability.

Conclusion

- The **Decade of Democracy (1988-1999)** in Pakistan was a time of hope and disappointment. After years of military rule, democracy returned to the country in 1988, but the dreams of a stable, prosperous democratic Pakistan never fully materialized. **Benazir Bhutto** and **Nawaz Sharif**, the two main political figures of the time, faced constant challenges that undermined their leadership.
- One of the biggest issues was the relationship between **civilian governments** and the **military**. Despite being elected, both leaders struggled to assert control over the military, which continued to interfere in politics and key decisions like **foreign policy** and **national security**. The military's role in shaping the country's future, even when not in power, made it clear that civilian authority was often secondary.
- **Corruption** also plagued this period. Allegations of mismanagement and misuse of power were rampant, with both Bhutto and Sharif accused of **money laundering** and other forms of corruption. This fueled public frustration and damaged the reputation of civilian governments. Alongside this, the country's economy was in poor shape, with high inflation, unemployment, and a growing foreign debt, making life harder for ordinary Pakistanis.
- Amidst all this, **political instability** was a constant theme. The frequent dismissal of prime ministers—whether by the president, the judiciary, or the military—further weakened the institutions of democracy. Instead of building strong democratic practices, the country saw a cycle of government changes, power struggles, and growing frustration with leadership.
- By the end of the decade, it became clear that civilian governments were not able to solve these deep-rooted problems. The military stepped in once again in **1999**, with **General Pervez Musharraf** taking control in a coup, ending the short-lived democratic experiment.
- In many ways, the **1990s** were a reminder of the challenges Pakistan faced in its struggle with democracy. Corruption, economic mismanagement, and military influence created a perfect storm that led to the collapse of civilian rule. While democracy offered hope, it was never fully given the chance to succeed, and once again, the military returned to power, taking the country into a new era of military rule.

"Pakistan: A Hard Country" by Anatol Lieven – A detailed exploration of Pakistan's complex political landscape, including the challenges of civilian rule and military influence.